

Chapter 7: The Silk Roads

Unit 2 • Ch. 7 • c. 1200–1450
AP World History: Modern

CUE COLUMN (cover & recall)	NOTES COLUMN (main content)
What were the Silk Roads?	A WEB of overland + maritime routes connecting China → Central Asia → Persia → Mediterranean → E. Africa • NOT one road — many parallel and overlapping routes • Overland routes: camel caravans through Central Asian oasis cities • Maritime routes: monsoon-driven dhows through Indian Ocean Key point: commercial, religious, and biological exchange all traveled the SAME routes
What moved along the routes?	GOODS: silk, porcelain, spices, horses, glass, cotton textiles, paper IDEAS: Islam, Buddhism, Nestorian Christianity, Sufism, Confucian thought TECHNOLOGY: paper, printing, gunpowder, magnetic compass (China → West) DISEASE: bubonic plague (<i>Yersinia pestis</i>) — the most deadly 'good' that traveled west
How did trade actually work? (mechanisms)	• Caravanserais: roadside inns every ~20 miles — shelter, water, trade space • Bills of exchange: early credit instruments replacing dangerous coin transport • Diasporic communities: Muslim merchants in every port → shared law & trust • Paper money: Chinese innovation adopted by Mongols for high-volume transactions • Camel caravans: Bactrian camel = 500 lb capacity, weeks without water
Pax Mongolica c. 1250s–1340s	= 'Mongol Peace' — period of unified Mongol rule enabling safe Eurasian travel • Mongols profited from taxing trade → rebuilt caravanserais, standardized weights • Made Marco Polo's journey (1271–95) and Ibn Battuta's travels (1304–68) possible • PARADOX: Mongol conquests first DESTROYED Silk Road cities, then REBUILT the network • When Mongol unity fragmented → routes became unsafe → maritime alternatives sought
Marco Polo vs. Ibn Battuta	Marco Polo (1254–1324): Venetian; traveled to Yuan China; Travels sparked European interest in Asia Ibn Battuta (1304–68): Moroccan Muslim; 75,000 miles; Rihla documents Islamic reach via trade Both traveled because of Pax Mongolica stability — their journeys are EVIDENCE of what it made possible AP Exam: expect primary source excerpts from one or both travelers as MCQ stimulus
The Black Death 1330s–1353	Cause: <i>Yersinia pestis</i> in Central Asian rodent populations; traveled trade routes westward Arrival in Europe: Genoese ships from Caffa (Crimea) to Sicily, 1347 Death toll: ~1/3 of Europe; similar in Middle East; contributed to Yuan collapse Social effects: labor shortages → serfdom erodes; Church authority challenged; Jewish pogroms Key concept: connectivity = plague risk. Same routes that carried silk carried disease
Why did the Silk Road decline?	• Yuan Dynasty collapses 1368 → eastern anchor of overland routes lost • Ilkhanate collapses mid-14th c. → Persia/Middle East segment destabilized • Political fragmentation → route security disappears → merchants seek alternatives • Maritime Indian Ocean routes MORE RESILIENT (driven by monsoons, not politics) • European states begin searching for direct maritime routes to Asia → Age of Exploration

AP Exam Tips
Ch. 7

★ HIGH-YIELD: Silk Roads appear as MCQ stimulus (traveler accounts) & DBQ source material

■ TRAP: Don't say Mongols 'spread' plague intentionally — it was unintended consequence

■ TRAP: Don't limit Silk Roads to commerce — always include religion, tech, disease

↔ COMPARE: Silk Roads (political stability needed) vs. Indian Ocean (monsoon-driven, resilient)

✓ CHAIN: Pax Mongolica → peak trade → plague travels → Mongol collapse → maritime routes → Exploration

SUMMARY — Write a 3-5 sentence synthesis in your own words:

The Silk Roads were not a single route but a web of overland and maritime connections that moved silk, spices, religions, technologies, and disease across Eurasia from c. 100 BCE through the 1400s. The Mongol Empire (c. 1206–1368) first destroyed key Silk Road cities, then rebuilt the network under the *Pax Mongolica*, enabling the journeys of Marco Polo and Ibn Battuta and the peak of Silk Road commerce. The SAME connectivity that enabled trade also enabled the bubonic plague, which traveled westward from Central Asia in the 1330s and killed roughly one-third of Europe's population by 1353. The Black Death destabilized Mongol rule, and as Mongol unity fragmented, the overland Silk Road lost its political infrastructure — driving merchants toward maritime alternatives and planting the seeds of the European Age of Exploration.

My summary in my own words:
